I came through Paris and London looking for more help. I often got volunteers for short bursts, but they'd burn out, understandably, or want something that paid in cash or glory. At one point I was shut up in a room in Paris on my own for two months while Nicolas Sarkozy was going about getting himself elected as president. It was spring 2007. I felt completely crushed, knowing WikiLeaks could be great, but that I was just ailing under the sheer volume of work required to make it happen. I was the only one doing the work, and it was hard to remember, on those Paris nights with the sound of laughter in the street below, that the site might actually do something good in the end. I had a girlfriend who would come round. She just brought food and I stayed at the computer. She spoke Russian, and would sometimes lend a hand with that, but it was a lonely time. Obsessional. I just couldn't see how to leave the computer.

Sometimes, I'd imagine I heard a squawk outside and think it must be one of the tropical birds from Magnetic Island. Or I'd feel for a second that sugar ants were running over the desk and across the floor. It got strangely warm as the days and weeks flowed on, with me trying to ensure that the submissions system for WikiLeaks would be totally right. Although I already had a large cache of material, we began attracting new stuff right away, and much of that new stuff came with a promise from me that we'd publish it. So I prioritised the new stuff, while also doing the final tinkering with the system, working out how people would email each other, and establishing how, say, the Kenyans would be able to get secure interaction. It was like setting up a branch office of the CIA. It was inevitable that WikiLeaks would, like any new business, have to grow organically: even more so, in our case, because it wasn't like a normal company where you had the financing and a business model under which the whole thing would be run by advertising or by fresh injections of venture capital. It wasn't like that. I was constantly searching for voluntary labour and having these online meetings that I'd scheduled. Once or twice, quite comically (though not at the time), I turned out to be the only person at those online meetings. And of course the whole thing was right on the border of schizophrenia: I'd be there, tapping away, being the Chair and the Secretary and bringing the next thing on the agenda and calling the vote. Mad. But I felt I had to go on as if the whole thing were possible, and that way it would really happen. In the same spirit of self-reinforcement, I would sometimes decide that a particular piece of work – writing an important press release, say – would